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Three Meals a Day as Compensatory Utopia: The Politics of Slow-Life Television, Neoliberal Anxiety, and Pastoral Spectacle

Three Meals a Day is a healing slow reality show produced by tvN, a cable TV under CJENM, and the famous producer and director Na-Yeon Seok. Since its first broadcast in 2014, it has quickly become one of the reality shows in South Korea. The production team sends celebrity guests to the countryside or fishing villages, making them away from high technology and the fast-paced city life. They need to be self-sufficient in obtaining ingredients for cooking, participate in farming and raising livestock, and get to know the lives of farmers. It shows the audience a picture of "slow life" that is completely opposite to the hustle and bustle of the city. This pastoral life is particularly attractive against the backdrop of the high-pressure urban society, and it also makes three meals a day a healing attribute. The audience in front of the screen can eliminate anxiety in temporary tranquility. However, this picture is not like what he shows that you can get healing by simply escaping from the city and returning to the countryside. It is just a utopian fantasy carefully packaged by capitalism - the intricate ideology and political and economic logic behind it are quietly hidden

This most "relaxing" program in South Korea's prime time actually starts with a lie: drones fly over the terraced fields, the sound of cicadas fills the surroundings, and the subtitles read "Return to the countryside and enjoy an ordinary day." The celebrity guests walk into the camera with backpacks on their backs and smile. In just a few minutes, the audience's attention has been captured - what greets them is not fierce competition or reversal suspense, but an ideal life state without deadlines, traffic jams and noise. This idyllic, conflict-free vision has propelled the show through five main seasons and four spin-offs, earning it placement on nearly every major streaming platform across Asia. Three Meals a day has become the backbone of the Korean Wave in the 2020s. The deep-seated condition for ***Three Meals a day*** to achieve such a great commercial success is that it sees the despair of urban Koreans caused by "Hell Joseon(North Korea)" (the high-pressure labor system), injects a dose of "pastoral placebo" into this anxiety, and then carefully designs to eliminate all structural contradictions that may undermine its healing effect from the screen. ***Three Meals A Day*** is like putting a filter on actual life, smoothing and polishing all the real states that can cause anxiety. Then it is filmed into a moving pastoral postcard and sent to the audience. Let the audience immerse themselves in the "Compensatory Utopianism" mentioned by Fredric Jameson which mean utopias can serve as a form of compensation for the alienations and sadness under capitalism. This article will take the criticism of neoliberalism, cultural industry theory and utopian research as the main framework

to reveal that ***Three Meals A Day*** (hereinafter referred to as ***TMAD***) conceals the real class differences and institutional problems under the mask of healing and packages them into consumable entertainment products.

Long shots linger on cabbage leaves trembling in the morning mist, fixed shots record steaming rice in real time, and the noisy background music common in Korean variety shows is replaced by the hissing of the wind and the bleating of sheep. A "slow-paced paradise" different from all modern life has emerged. The camera deliberately avoids the entry of real rural survival problems such as broken tractors, unpaid bills, and aging populations. Even several days of shooting are edited into a seamless seasonal cycle, telling the story of months of agricultural labor compressed into a quick "sowing-harvest-dinner" clip. All the conflicting facts, people, and sounds being subtract until the remaining picture looks calm, authentic, and innocent. The countryside is emptied of contradictions so that it can absorb the city's fantasy of authenticity.

The rural backdrop in ***TMAD*** is little more than a different kind of the stage set hidden underneath the “heal”. What hooks viewers is the safe thrill of peeking at celebrities when the city lights shut down. A 2024 feature in the Korea JoongAng Daily captured this affective sell in its headline “Go Rural, Get Ratings,” it point out that nothing make audiences felt “strangely healed watching star do almost nothing.” revealing that the real selling point of the show is not the action or the plot, but the commodification of “rural utopia” and star power.. Korean pop-culture site Seoul Beats reached the same conclusion years earlier, describing the series as a show where the fun lies in “put actor Lee Seo-jin … in a secluded village house and ask him to cook,” an arrangement that “sent Korean audiences into a frenzy” because it let them spy on stars outside their comfort zone and private state. Real farmers, their debts, and the demographic hollowing of the countryside rarely appeal. The thrill is therefore voyeuristic rather than empathetic: the viewer feels the illusion of intimacy with the star and the peaceful they saw from screen rather than an understanding of the actual hardships of rural livelihoods.

TMAD advertising itself as a healing show, but the so-called “healing” it presents is essentially a carefully designed industrial illusion. The production team carefully selected hundreds of hours of raw materials, retaining only those clips with a slow rhythm, and then artificially created an ideal atmosphere through the superposition of environmental sound effects and delicate color processing. Even the most difficult farm work such as picking wild vegetables, which is extremely arduous for farmers, was romantic and simplified during the editing process. This romanticized presentation of rural life perfectly confirms the concept of “pastoral myth” proposed by historian Raymond Williams. By reconstructing rural time and space and stripping away the historical dimension, nature is alienated into a cultural machine for the spiritual comfort of urban people.

This mythological narrative has resonated strongly in contemporary Korean society. After experiencing a rapid industrialization process, Korean urbanites are trapped in the siege of “Ppalli ppalli culture” (Fast culture), long working hours and success anxiety. The illusion of

slow life created by ***TMAD*** provides them with a temporary spiritual refuge, but deliberately avoids the cruel reality that rural South Korea is experiencing population shrinkage, aging, and the survival pressure brought by industrialized agriculture. The so-called "healing" sold by the program is actually the result of decontextualizing and commercializing rural life - it erases all traces of hardship and packages it into an aesthetic experience that urban elites can consume.

This narrative simplifies the complex rural landscape into a background board for self-healing. For viewers trapped in the high-pressure life of Seoul, this carefully modified pastoral fantasy is indeed irresistible. But the price is that the real rural plight – farmers' sweat, debt and loneliness - completely disappears in front of the camera, leaving only the purified natural image. The emergence of this cultural phenomenon is no accident. Among OECD countries, South Korea has long maintained the highest record of working hours. Seoul's high housing prices and worrying youth suicide rates continue to stimulate people's yearning for slow life. As the Korean version of The Economist observed as early as 2015, the popularity of slow food and slow life programs is essentially a mild protest against the Korean development model. The success of ***TMAD*** lies precisely in its transformation of this collective anxiety into a consumable cultural commodity.

Interpreted with Mark Fisher's theory of "capitalist realism", this phenomenon reveals a deeper paradox: institutional pressure has not led to structural change but has instead spawned a series of individualized solutions that have been incorporated by capital. The aesthetic strategy of ***TMAD*** deliberately avoids all real rural problems. Just like a spa treating cervical spondylosis, the "cure" it provides always stays at the level of symptom relief. Not only can it not touch the root of the problem, but it also invisibly eliminates the collective motivation to change the status quo. The paradox of this cultural consumerism is that it not only exploits the spiritual dilemma of urban people for profit, but also cleverly avoids questioning and challenging the system itself by personalizing the problem.

Cooking, in ***TMAD,*** is just surface narrative; the true spectacle is an endlessly exportable package of "Koreanness." The show first pins down local identity via subtitle badges—Gangwon potatoes, Jeju squid, Jeonbuk chilies—then completes the cultural filing with table etiquette: under Korean dining rules, elders eat first, and younger people must wait. Still more conspicuous is the re-labeling of guest dynamics: regardless of their real relationships, the production compresses everyone into "Dad/Mom/Son," turning the scene into a nuclear family drama. A 2022 article in the Journal of the Korea Contents Association argues that this practice "re-writes the modern nuclear family through a patriarchal lens," reproducing a tiny patriarchal nation behind a warm filter. The moment local ingredients and Confucian rites share the same frame, they click into the national branding strategy: a 2024 Ministry of Agriculture paper pledges that Korean cuisine will "lead global gastronomic trends by 2027." ***TMAD***'s 4-K close-ups thereby become natural K-Food ads. When overseas viewers comment, "This stone-pot soup smells like the home I never had," homesickness merges seamlessly with product desire; The Guardian likewise calls Korean soft power a "serious business," with culture now a main engine of economic growth.

That seemingly inclusive rural picture, however, obeys a strict industrial template. No matter which village or celebrity appears, ***TMAD*** sticks to the same formula—local ingredient + family caption + Confucian order—vacuum-packing "Traditional Korea" for single-click distribution on Netflix. Region, family, and ritual fold into a replicable, transmissible cultural label; as viewers savor "tradition," they simultaneously buy into Korean national imagery and commercial goods. In TMAD, every structural problem shrinks into a do-it-yourself bet on personal grit. If Lee Seo-jin can build a chicken coop before lunch, the show implies a Seoul tenant who hasn't planted balcony lettuce lacks only determination. The lattice of subsidies, co-op loans, and seasonal migrant labor supporting agriculture vanishes, turning neoliberal doctrine— "a political project to re-establish the conditions for capital accumulation and to restore the power of economic elites"—into cozy entertainment. CJ ENM bankrolls production, while its food subsidiary sells shelf-stable bibimbap; the moment YouTube clips go live, purchase links follow viewers home pages. Media scholar Lee Hye-Kyung notes that Hallyu has become "an effective vehicle for implicit cultural policies concerning the formation of a neoliberal subjectivity." ***TMAD*** harvests rural emotion, cans it, and ships it straight to global streaming shelves.

The economics of that extraction follow the logic Guy Debord framed in Thesis 4 of The Society of the Spectacle: "The spectacle is not a collection of images, but a social relation among people, mediated by images." 4K drone footage does not just capture fields, it also transforms the countryside into a transaction between urban audiences and the CJENM shopping cart: enjoy the slow grinding of soybean paste in a stone mortar on Friday night, scan the code to take away the room temperature instant version on Monday morning, and plan a route with the travel agency on Saturday and Sunday to go to the same countryside where the show was filmed to experience the same slow life of the celebrities. In order to make this chain to run smoothly which is make the audience willing to buy the ideology. The show must appear spontaneous and uncontrollable to keep things natural but never deviate from the template. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's critique of the culture industry is prophetic: "Culture today is infecting everything with sameness,", and "The culture industry perpetually cheats its consumers of what it perpetually promise". The script of handmade-meals-shared-sunset in ***TMAD*** is repeated season by season, with an occasional "runaway goat" or "overly salty hot sauce" added to create a pseudo-uniqueness, making the audience willing to follow the show and spend money on it.

Since the early 2000s, the South Korean government has gradually reduced its subsidies in the agricultural sector, moving away from direct subsidies to a market-driven strategy centered on emotional branding and cultural output. Where farmers once relied on state-backed price subsidies—which accounted for 70% of total agricultural income in the late 1980s—they now extract value through integration with the food, tourism, and entertainment industries. By 2016, producer subsidies had fallen to just 49%, reflecting a broader policy shift to view rural life less as an economic necessity and more as a cultural commodity. This new approach redefines the countryside as a repository of tradable nostalgia, where emotions are monetized through media such as ***TMAD***. Produced by a subsidiary of CJ ENM, the show not only depicts slow living but

also nourishes a business ecosystem. Each scene of rural food cleverly advertises products such as CJ-owned Bibigo, which saw sales surge 45% in Europe in early 2024. Meanwhile, South Korean food exports—including kimchi, instant noodles, and rice cakes—reached a record $6.21 billion in the first half of 2024, testament to the lucrative nature of selling an idealized rural aesthetic.

The reality, however, is profoundly unequal. Farmers receive less than 0.1% of the value chain, while corporations and the state take the lion's share. The system is built on a paradox: it promotes the countryside as a remedy for urban stress, but at the same time it exacerbates it. South Korea's notorious work culture, with long hours and soaring suicide rates, drives demand for escapist content. The government has spent $322 million on programs to combat loneliness while refusing to address its root cause: competitive pressures. Just like the show ***TMAD***, it offer only temporary relief, shoehorning idyllic rural life into the market logic they are meant to escape. The result is a vicious cycle. Urban exhaustion breeds demand for rural fantasies; fantasies breed export growth; and export success justifies further subsidy cuts. What was initially depicted as a simple life eventually turned into a global shopping cart - with farmers marginalized and structural fatigue remaining intact.

The pastoral life model promoted by ***TMAD*** has proven remarkably adaptable across borders, with its slow-living model stripped of politics and repackaged in the service of competing national narratives. Hunan TV's ***Back to the Field*** (2017) replicates the South Korean show's formula—stars working the fields, artisanal cooking, idyllic scenery—but grafts it onto a unique national framework. The show's title card and official propaganda explicitly link the show to China's "rural revitalization" policy, and it has been hailed by the Central Propaganda Department as a "new model for agricultural civilization film and television creation."

The contrast between the two is instructive. ***TMAD*** peddles personalized craftsmanship and branded nostalgia, while ***Back to the Field*** constructs farming life as a collective project that aligns with Beijing's modernization goals. Yet beneath these surface differences, both shows act as pressure valves to relieve urban fatigue. The South Korean version is designed to allow people to escape from a competitive society plagued by long work hours and mental health crises; the Chinese version taps into people's disillusionment with rapid urbanization and inequality. The packaging styles of the two are very different – "healing slow life" in ***TMAD*** and "rural revitalization" in ***Back to the Field*** - but the mechanism is consistent: audience fatigue is converted into an engagement indicator.

These programs criticize accelerationism by glorifying slowness, but their success accelerates the system they criticize. Viewers flock to watch these programs to seek respite, but ultimately get a new round of clicks, ads, and commodities. The countryside, once a site of material labor, has become a backdrop for emotional labor - an arena where emotions are mined for value. Both reveal how the anxiety of late capitalism is commodified under different political systems. Whether in the context of South Korea's elimination of agricultural subsidies or China's

government-led revitalization plan, the pastoral ideal is no longer a place, but a product - it thrives by promising unattainable escape.

Someone may ask: Is there still real hope for such an ideologically charged show? The answer lies in the gap between the silence of the screen and the reality of the audience. Forty-something office workers watch TV shows in the middle of the night because their kitchens are small, and their commutes are long; fresh graduates submit resumes while watching TV shows. Utopian desires are honest, and for this reason, their assimilation by CJENM and the state will never be complete. Uncovering the contradictions hidden by ***Three Meals a Day*** - the aging of rural areas, dependence on migrant workers, and the tightening of subsidies year by year - is the first step to push it from an "emotional painkiller" to a real public issue; the second step that follows is to translate the personal healing demands aroused by the show into specific policy proposals: reducing working hours, restoring green agricultural subsidies, and establishing land trusts in the suburbs of cities, so that "slow cooking and eating together" is no longer just a compensatory fantasy scene, but a life right that citizens can truly enjoy.

Three Meals a Day is an ideological machine: it transforms widespread dissatisfaction with the high-speed and high-pressure economy into a pastoral spectacle, appeasing domestic audiences through individualized and commercialized slow-life aesthetics, while promoting exportable traditional Korean images to the world. Its political and economic foundation is a mechanism that seamlessly connects utopian desires with commercial profits. The need for criticism is to expose its compensatory function, to return the common desire aroused by the stone pot rice on the screen to the field of politics and public life, and to make the slow and shared taste a possible daily life, rather than just a silent dream on a digital platform.

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